DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Can We Ever Know What God Is?

Derech Hashem 1:1:2-5

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 1, Chapter 1, paragraphs 2-5 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Wednesday 30 December 2020

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The first ten minutes of this class were not recorded; the recording begins in the middle of paragraph 2.

Paragraph 2: His essence is beyond us

The second thing we must know is that no one can fathom the essence of Hakadosh Barukh Hu. The Rabbi quoted the line he attributed to Rav Saadiah Gaon: "Ilu yedativ, hayitiv," "If I knew Him, I would be Him."

This ties back to the previous class on daat: truly knowing something means connecting to it, almost becoming part of it. To know Hashem in that way you would have to be Him, which is impossible. Human beings, with all our limitations and boundaries, cannot understand Him. Only God can know God.

But do we not describe Him? We call Hashem merciful, compassionate and slow to anger. The Rabbi explained that these words never describe Hashem Himself; the Rambam would say it is heresy to claim we can describe Him. They describe the way He relates to us: He deals with us in a merciful, compassionate and truthful way. The one thing we can say about Hashem Himself is that He is shalem, perfect with the utmost perfection.

Tradition and proof

The Ramhal then notes that everything he has said so far is a kabbalah, a tradition from our fathers and the prophets, which all of Israel perceived at Mount Sinai and which was verified clearly to them there. The Rabbi linked this to Moshe's command never to forget what we saw, and to pass it on to our children and grandchildren: this is the misvah of passing on the masorah.

The Ramhal adds that all of this can also be proven through investigation and logical demonstration, from what we observe in nature, through physics, astronomy and other wisdoms. But he will not do that here. He will set the principles out as they are, clearly, as a tradition renowned in our nation.

The Rabbi brought the Ramban on the Torah, who famously says that the standing at Mount Sinai is the greatest proof of our emunah. No other religion has ever claimed mass revelation:

in other faiths God reveals Himself to one individual, whereas at Sinai He revealed Himself to hundreds of thousands at once. That is the meaning of "You have seen" (atem reitem): not through a messenger who saw on your behalf, but with your own eyes, passed on from generation to generation.

Paragraph 3: Existence that must be

The third principle: this First Being's existence is imperative (mehuyav, mukhrah). It is impossible for Him not to exist. The Rabbi noted that this is almost a direct quotation from the Rambam at the very start of Hilchot Yesodei HaTorah (1:2): if one were to imagine that Hashem does not exist, nothing else could exist.

Some things exist but do not have to exist. "Do you have to exist? You don't have to exist. Your spouse may think you have to exist, your children may think you have to exist, but you don't really have to exist." The universe does not have to exist. Hashem's existence, however, must be.

This also answers the question children often ask: "Who created God?" or "What was before Him?" If His existence were not necessary, you would need a reason for it. Because it is necessary, the question is "a non-starter."

Paragraph 4: Not dependent on anything

The fourth principle: His existence does not depend on anything else; He exists of Himself.

The Rabbi asked the group what this adds to paragraph 3. His answer: something can have to exist and still depend on something else. He gave the example of the Torah: the Midrash tells us the Torah existed before the world was created, so the concept of Torah had to be, yet it depends on something beyond itself. Paragraph 3 tells us that Hashem must exist. Paragraph 4 tells us that this necessity comes from Himself, intrinsically, and not from anything outside Him.

Put simply: "One thing is: I have to have you here because I need you. Another is: you have to be here, and that 'have to be' comes from yourself."

Paragraph 5: A simple existence

The fifth principle, which the Ramhal himself says is very hard to explain: Hashem's existence is simple, without different factors and parts, and all the perfections we mentioned exist in Him in a plain and simple way.

In every human being, each strength has its own borders. Memory is one faculty, will is another, imagination another, and none of them enters the other. One person is very clever and generous but has no imagination; another is different. Even when a person has both a good memory and a strong will, the two are not linked: they are separate things that happen to be found in the same person.

The Rabbi then asked us to imagine a perfect human being, with every good quality to the highest degree: wisdom, imagination, will, determination, generosity. Would that be like Hakadosh Barukh Hu? No, because those qualities would still be many separate things. And

they would still be additions to the person: we have "Moshe," and then we have "Moshe's wisdom." Other people lack them, so they are not essential to being human.

Hashem is not like that. "It's not that you have a God and you have wisdom and He's wise... God is wanting, willing, determining, everything, all in one essence called God." His perfections are not something added to His essence; they are His essence itself.

The Ramhal's next words admit that he almost has no words to express this, because we human beings, by the way we were created and by what our senses bring us, only understand limited and separate things. The Rabbi said he would explain this further in the next class, and use it to explain an important point in the Rambam about Hashem's knowledge and free will.

Questions

At the end, a participant asked: if Hashem is perfect, where does evil come from? The Rabbi said this is a basic question, and that the book discusses it later on.

Summary

- Paragraph 2: Hashem's essence cannot be grasped; His "attributes" describe how He relates to us, and the one thing we can say of Him is that He is perfect.
- These truths are a tradition from Sinai, the only claimed mass revelation, and can also be proven by reason, though the Ramhal chooses not to prove them here.
- Paragraph 3: His existence is necessary, so "Who created God?" is not a real question.
- Paragraph 4: That necessity comes from Himself, not from anything else.
- Paragraph 5: His existence is simple: all His perfections are one with His essence, not separate qualities added to Him.

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